

Cybersecurity Risk Register and Improvement Plan

Prioritized leadership view of cyber risk aligned to NIST CSF 2.0

OWNER
CTO / Cybersecurity Governance Committee

DISTRICT
Ardent ISD

REVIEW CYCLE
Annual + after major incident

POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE

CQB

strategic technology plan

budget

Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

How Ardent ISD Uses This Register

The purpose is not to list every technical weakness. It is to identify **material district risks**, assign ownership, prioritize limited resources, and make progress visible to cabinet and the board. The register uses the NIST CSF 2.0 functions - **Govern, Identify, Protect, Detect, Respond, Recover** - as a common language.

Scoring

- Likelihood: 1 Rare - 5 Likely
- Impact: 1 Low - 5 Severe
- Inherent risk = Likelihood × Impact
- Residual risk = risk remaining after current safeguards

Risk scores support judgment; they do not replace it.

Sample 2026 Ardent ISD Register

ID	NIST	Risk statement	L	I	Inherent	Existing safeguards	Residual	Priority action	Owner	Target
R-01	Protect	Privileged account compromise could enable	4	5	20	MFA; separate admin IDs	12	phishing-resistant MFA for Tier 0 admins;	CTO	Q2

ID	NIST	Risk statement	L	I	Inherent	Existing safeguards	Residual	Priority action	Owner	Target
		broad access across SSO, cloud, and infrastructure						quarterly access review		
R-02	Recover	Backups may not restore critical systems within required time during ransomware	3	5	15	daily backups; offsite copy	10	quarterly restore test for SIS, ERP, identity; immutable copy	Infrastructure	Q2
R-03	Govern	Vendor security/ privacy review is inconsistent across campus purchases	4	4	16	procurement review for major contracts	12	require Artifact 10 for all tools receiving protected data	Procurement + Privacy	Q1
R-04	Identify	District lacks complete inventory of SaaS applications and data owners	4	4	16	SSO app list; finance vendor list	12	build reconciled SaaS/data inventory	CTO + Finance	Q2
R-05	Detect	Cloud account compromise may persist too long before detection	3	5	15	native alerts; endpoint tools	9	centralize identity/ cloud logs; tune high-risk alerts	Security	Q3
R-06	Protect	Legacy service accounts have excessive privileges and non-expiring secrets	4	4	16	partial password vaulting	12	inventory/ rotate; managed identities where feasible	Systems	Q3
R-07	Respond	Incident leadership may lose contact if SSO/email/ VoIP fail together	3	4	12	staff cell directory	8	offline contact tree + quarterly test	CTO + Communications	Q1
R-08	Recover	Recovery order is not agreed across instructional/	3	4	12	DR plan	9	cabinet-approved service	CTO + CFO	Q2

ID	NIST	Risk statement	L	I	Inherent	Existing safeguards	Residual	Priority action	Owner	Target
		business leaders						criticality/ RTO map		
R-09	Protect	Portable exports containing employee SPI could be stored unencrypted	3	5	15	endpoint encryption; policy	8	block unmanaged USB; encrypted transfer workflow; DLP pilot	HR + IT	Q2
R-10	Govern	Staff may place protected data into unapproved generative AI tools	4	4	16	acceptable use guidance	12	approved AI list; data handling training; technical controls	CTO + Curriculum	Q1
R-11	Respond	Vendor breach notices may arrive without enough details to meet district clocks	3	4	12	standard contract clause	8	strengthen DPA incident clause; vendor contact register	Legal + Procurement	Q2
R-12	Protect	MFA fatigue/ social engineering could bypass traditional push-based MFA	4	4	16	MFA required	10	number matching/ stronger factors; targeted training	Security	Q2

Improvement Plan: Top Five Priorities

Priority 1 - Privileged Identity Protection

Outcome: Tier 0/critical administrators use stronger MFA; access reviewed quarterly.

Evidence: access-review log, authentication policy, reduction in standing admin access.

Budget: \$18,000 estimated implementation/keys/training.

Tradeoff: additional administrative friction for a small number of high-risk accounts.

Priority 2 - Tested Recovery

Outcome: Ardent can demonstrate recovery of identity, SIS, ERP, and critical file services from protected backups.

Evidence: quarterly restore test with actual measured RTO/RPO and gaps.

Board message: "We do not call a backup successful until we have restored from it."

Priority 3 - Vendor Governance

Outcome: Any tool receiving protected district data completes the Vendor Security & Privacy Review Packet before procurement/renewal.

Evidence: approval register, renewal dates, data owners, completed reviews, rejected/conditioned vendors.

Priority 4 - SaaS / Data Inventory

Outcome: District can answer “Which vendors hold student or employee data, who owns the relationship, and when does the contract end?”

Evidence: reconciled inventory across SSO, finance, procurement, curriculum, and campus purchasing.

Priority 5 - Incident Communications Resilience

Outcome: Incident team can coordinate even when district SSO/email/VoIP is unavailable.

Evidence: offline contact sheet, alternate conference method, tabletop test results.

Quarterly Cyber Governance Dashboard

Indicator	Target	Current sample	Status
Critical systems with tested restore in last 90 days	100%	75%	Needs work
Tier 0 admins using strongest approved MFA	100%	62%	Needs work
Tier 1 vendors with current risk review	100%	68%	Needs work
Staff cybersecurity training completion	100%	97%	Watch
High-risk findings past target date	0	3	Needs work
Incident tabletop exercises completed this year	1+	1	On track

Governance Review Questions

1. Which residual risks are above the district's tolerance?
2. Which risks need superintendent/board awareness because mitigation requires funding or policy change?
3. Which risks are being accepted, by whom, and until when?
4. What evidence shows that a control works, rather than merely exists?
5. What new risks came from vendor changes, AI adoption, staffing, or infrastructure changes?

References

- NIST Cybersecurity Framework 2.0
- CISA - Protecting Our Future: Cybersecurity for K-12
- K12 SIX - Cybersecurity Essentials Series and Incident Response Runbook
- CoSN - K-12 Community Vendor Assessment Tool (K-12CVAT)
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements